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« Shubman Gill gives India a right-left balance with Abhishek Sharma at the top, and as Test captain, he's well-placed to grow into an even bigger leadership role when the time comes

though, will need to evolve if he is to fit India's increasingly high-risk approach. Since its T20 World Cup triumph last year, India has floored the accelerator, scoring at 9.90 runs per over — second only to Australia's 10.11. During this period, Abhishek and Samson opened 12 times, striking at 193.84 and 171.47 respectively, and combining for five centuries. Jaiswal, too, pressed his claim with a strike rate of 170, but he

has been pushed into the reserves.

Like Samson, Shreyas was a casualty of top-order congestion. The Punjab Kings skipper was the only batter in the latest IPL to score more than 600 runs at a strike rate above 170, but most of that success came at No. 3. That slot now belongs to Tilak Varma, who has two centuries and a fifty in his last seven T20I innings, enough to force captain Suryakumar Yadav down

to No. 4. The selectors see little value in using Shreyas outside the top four, even though he dominated the death overs (16–20) in IPL 2025 with a strike rate of 227.84. His and Jaiswal's omission, neither has played a T20I in over a year, signals the panel's horses-for-courses outlook, where IPL form carries only so much weight. Abhishek and Tilak, though quieter in the IPL, have delivered in India colours and thus hold sway.

Team balance has been another recurring theme. The management insists on batting depth until No. 8 and six bowling options, effectively mandating three all-rounders. Hardik Pandya and Axar Patel, though stripped of the vice-captaincy, remain automatic picks. But the third all-rounder slot is unsettled. Shivam Dube offers middle-order hitting but is rarely trusted to bowl. He has delivered just 10 overs in six T20Is since last year's World Cup, and across four seasons with Chennai Super Kings bowled only five. Harshit Rana can support Jasprit Bumrah as a second seamer, but he lacks batting credentials and has been expensive, going at more than 10 an over in IPL 2025. Dube, for his part, struggled against spin, striking at only 118.80 this year.

Washington Sundar, who featured in 11 of India's 20 T20Is since the World Cup, could have been a neat solution, but he finds himself only